



DELHI | Sugar and Spice

Is Mamata Banerjee the new Lalu Yadav? Her girlish bonhomie with the Congress president is being compared to Lalu's famed rapport with Sonia Gandhi during UPA I. The Mamata-Sonia duo recently flagged off 12 new trains from Kanpur. Since the Trinamool Congress has zero presence in the state, it's easy to see who benefits. Speaking at a rally in Kanpur, Banerjee was quick to remind the audience that this was a state that nurtures prime ministers and announced, "The nation's future too is in the hands of this very state," a not-so-shrouded reference to Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi that made her the first UPA ally to officially dub Gandhi Jr as the next prime minister. In 2004, Lalu was the first to support Sonia as the prime ministerial candidate before a falling out. Obviously, the Most Favoured Ally status does not get very far with the Congress. The NCP wasn't scoring too much in the bonhomie stakes though. Two days after the Congress Working Committee meet targeted Sharad Pawar on the price rise, he called on old friend and Congress *bête noir*, Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray, ostensibly to discuss cricket. Last year too when the Congress was acting tough with the NCP on seat-sharing, Pawar paid Thackeray a visit. After Rahul's *aam-aadmi* tryst with the Sena, the Congress is not amused. But Pawar obviously is not sweet as sugar either.

**BANERJEE
AND SONIA
FLAGGING
OFF TRAINS
AT KANPUR**

by Priya Sahgal

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is Banerjee's new line to please Sonia. She wants Rahul as the next prime minister from Uttar Pradesh, a state that has sent eight already.